

APM Project Management Qualification

Learner Study Pack



Diversity and Inclusion

Introduction

This section of the Learner Study Pack will cover the Diversity and Inclusion competence of the APM Project Management Qualification. The training on this topic should enable learners to gain an understanding of the benefits and responsibilities of embracing diversity and treating people fairly.

Learning objective and outcomes

Learning objective:

14. Diversity and inclusion: Understand diversity and inclusion as the ability to build and maintain an inclusive environment that embraces a diverse culture.

By the end of this activity, you should be able to:

14a) Knowledge of diversity, including characteristics which may cause a person to be treated less favourably, such as: age, disability, marriage and civil partnership, pregnancy and maternity, race, religion or belief, sex, and sexual orientation.

14b) Understand why incorporating diversity into all parts of a project, from team members to customers, is a factor in creating a positive working environment. And understand the importance of embracing diverse thinking in teams as a means of generating innovative solutions.

14c) Understand how conscious and unconscious bias can affect actions. And know how to treat people fairly, including adapting behaviours to support individuals' needs and facilitate their contributions.

Study time

This section of the Learner Study Pack will take approximately 1 - 2 hours to complete.

Recommended resources

In addition to your Learner Study Pack, use the below references for more information on Diversity and Inclusion:

- APM Body of Knowledge Seventh edition, 3.2.6 Diversity and inclusion.
- APM Learning Module, Creating an environment of inclusion. Accessed at: <https://www.apm.org.uk/resources/apm-learning/>
- APM What is diversity and inclusion in project management? Accessed at: <https://www.apm.org.uk/resources/what-is-project-management/what-is-diversity-and-inclusion-in-project-management/>
- APM Blog Mythbusting diversity and inclusion in project management. Accessed at: <https://www.apm.org.uk/blog/mythbusting-diversity-and-inclusion-in-project-management/>
- The Value of Difference: Eliminating Bias in the Workplace (2009)

- The implicit bias test Accessed at: <https://implicit.harvard.edu/implicit/>
- UK protected characteristics. Accessed at: <https://www.gov.uk/discrimination-your-rights>

Overview

Diversity and inclusion (D&I) refers to embracing and respecting differences among individuals, including but not limited to, race, gender, age, ethnicity, sexual orientation and abilities.

The goal is to create environments where everyone feels valued, heard and can contribute their unique perspectives, fostering innovation and equity.

Knowledge of Diversity

Diversity is of great value to projects as it leads to higher performance through diverse skill sets and perspectives, which in turn helps to enable the successful delivery of outcomes.

Project-based working is made up of teams with different backgrounds, experiences and capabilities which should be embraced.

National cultures are developed over long periods of time and are influenced by different drivers, which in turn influence people's values and beliefs, which are influential in shaping people's behaviours.

As part of stakeholder analysis project professionals may wish to consider researching different cultures to understand typical behaviours.

In many countries, it is illegal to discriminate against people based on protected characteristics, e.g. their age, race, religion, gender, or sexual orientation. It is important that project professionals, if unsure, seek advice on how to treat people fairly, particularly as protected characteristics can vary by country.

Incorporating Diversity

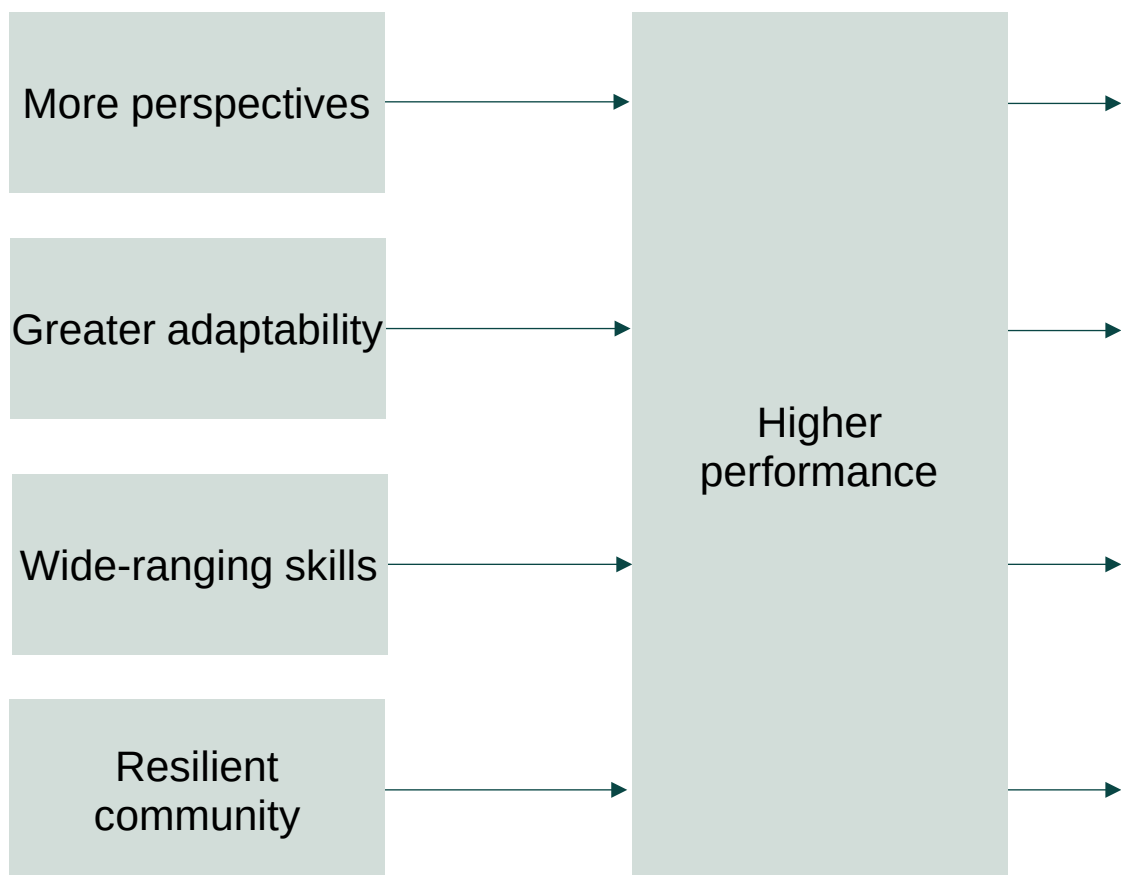
In project-based working, temporary teams come together and need to perform quickly. These teams can be based in the same office or span across different countries or continents.

Leadership and communication styles are enabling factors to maximise opportunities to create an open, honest and psychologically safe environment.

Consideration must be given to the different individuals' perspectives, abilities and any reasonable adjustments required to form ways of working that enables a positive working environment and ensures everyone has a fair chance.

Questions to assist with this consideration include:

- Do people feel they can be themselves at work?
- Are people encouraged to share ideas, and challenge respectfully?
- Do people understand and welcome differences?



Conscious and Unconscious Bias

Conscious and unconscious biases are ingrained preferences or prejudices that influence our perceptions and decision making.

Conscious bias involves deliberate thoughts and attitudes, while unconscious bias operates involuntarily, often stemming from societal stereotypes.

Understanding and addressing these biases is crucial for promoting fair and equitable treatment as they can affect our understanding, actions, and decisions in an implicit manner.

Here are some practices that can be used to ensure that people are treated fairly:

- Create and sustain a positive, inclusive working environment and address any potential barriers.
- Make reasonable adjustments to ensure that all individuals have a fair chance.
- Explore how differences can be managed to achieve a common purpose.
- Recognise contributions that can be made by individual team members.
- Ensure communication at an organisational and individual level is conducted in a meaningful way.
- Enable multiple dimensions of culture to exist - including gender, religious beliefs, race, marital status, ethnicity, parental status, age, education, physical and mental ability, income, sexual orientation, occupation, language, geographic location, etc
- Balance priorities of any project and active acceptance of the need to treat people fairly.
- Lead by example - demonstrate appropriate behaviours and communication.
- Adapt individual working styles and organisational ways of working to facilitate contributions from all team members.
- Explore and respond to signs of bias and recognise signs of resistance, either individually or organisationally, to inclusion and diversity.

Scenario One:

Ayo, the Founder/CEO, has always been a huge advocate for diversity and inclusion within every workplace and they want the new Snappy Appy offices to be no different!

After talking to several of the employees about what facilities they would like to see included as part of the renovation, the creation of a designated prayer space has been suggested.

Ayo wants to ensure that employees of various faiths have a quiet and respectful place for religious practices and is very keen to have this space incorporated into the renovation project.

What physical changes and functionality should you consider to create a respectful and ‘fit for purpose’ prayer space within the office, as part of the renovation project?

Apart from physically creating the space, what considerations/processes/procedures might you have to implement about education, communication and policy inclusions?

What potential signs of resistance could you potentially see from some employees to the installation of a designated prayer space?

How could you address these signs of resistance to promote inclusivity?

Scenario Two:

Lee, the HR Manager, has just heard about the prayer space and absolutely loves the idea!

They know that a diverse and inclusive workplace is very attractive to potential employees and thinks that this will make recruitment for the company much easier.

Lee would like to include some information on the recruitment page of the Snappy Appy website to promote the prayer space and the company's drive to create a more diverse and inclusive workspace.

Draft a summary about the shared prayer space that could be included on the recruitment page of the Snappy Appy website.

Aside from making the company more appealing from a recruitment perspective, what are some of the additional benefits of having facilities like a shared prayer space in the workplace?

Learning review questions

Before you attempt the exam practice questions in the next section, we recommend you review your learning to quickly see which aspects you don't understand or can't remember as well.

It will also boost your confidence by confirming what you have learnt and your demonstrated ability to apply that knowledge, so that you are ready to practise for the exam.

Here are some questions you may wish to answer to review your learning from the Leadership section:

- What are different ways that you can create an inclusive working environment?
- What might be some of the challenges associated with managing a diverse project team?
- What strategies could be used to overcome those challenges?
- How might unconscious biases affect project outcomes?
- What would be appropriate inclusive communication and behaviours within a project?
- What could different signs be that people are resistant to diversity and inclusion?
- Why is it important for companies to address and mitigate conscious and unconscious biases in the workplace?

Exam practice questions

14.1 It is against the law to discriminate against someone because of a protected characteristic. Which of the following combination of characteristics are all legally protected? (1 Mark)

- a. Gender, economic status, and political affiliation
- b. Age, disability, and marital status
- c. Sexual orientation, educational background, and language proficiency
- d. Social status, race, and having a criminal record

14.2 You are appointed as a project manager on an international project working across various industries, multiple countries, cultures and backgrounds. You are keen to create a positive working environment for all.

Which one of the following statements are true when considering diversity and Inclusion within this project?
(1 mark)

- a. It is more effective to ensure that people work within their countries and cultures, to avoid conflict and disagreements.
- b. Biases are acceptable because it is human nature to favour people and things which are 'different from' us, rather than 'like us'.
- c. Unconscious biases are biases that individuals know they have and need to conceal.
- d. Academic evidence supports the view that different experiences, perspectives and backgrounds will positively impact performance.

14.3 In a multinational corporation, a diverse project team is working on a complex project with tight deadlines. The team members come from various cultural backgrounds, each bringing unique perspectives and skills. As the project progresses, you notice subtle signs of favouritism in assignments and decision making.

How would you address the challenge of conscious and unconscious bias affecting actions, ensuring a fair and equitable work environment?
(1 mark)

- 1. Assign tasks based on team members' cultural backgrounds to leverage their strengths.
- 2. Ignore potential biases to maintain efficiency and project timelines.
- 3. Address biases through awareness training and implement objective criteria for task assignments.
- 4. Rotate leadership roles among team members to minimise the impact of bias.
- 5. Review the team's CVs to understand their strengths and required development.
- 6. Ask each team member to explain their cultural background and why it differs from others on the team.

Choose the correct combination of statements:

- a. 4 & 6
- b. 1 & 3
- c. 2 & 5
- d. 3 & 5

14.4 What are five examples of characteristics which may cause a person to be treated unfairly or less favourably?
(5 marks)

14.5

You are managing a project to create a new set of HR policies for your organisation. Since the project will impact everyone in the organisation, you're keen to build a project team that contains a diverse mix of people working within a positive working environment.

What are three benefits the project team will gain by having team members from a mixture of diverse backgrounds?
(3 marks)

What are two behaviours that would demonstrate the project is a positive environment for the team to work within?
(2 marks)

14.6 Embracing diverse thinking in teams is crucial for generating innovative solutions because it encourages____(a)_____.

To further support a positive working environment, it is important that the project team members _____(b)_____.

(2 marks)

(a)

1. Conflict resolution
2. Open communication
3. Risk management
4. Technical expertise

(b)

1. Understand and welcome difference
2. Avoid disagreeing with each other
3. Avoid escalating concerns
4. Often meet in person

Exam practice answers

Question	Answer / Mark scheme
14.1	B
14.2	D
14.3	D
14.4	1 mark for any of the below, or other correct answer, 5 marks available in total: • Age • Sex • Gender identity • Sexual Orientation • Pregnancy/Maternity • Race • Religion or Belief • Language • Regional accent • Clothing choices • Hairstyles • Marital status • Socioeconomic background • Nationality • Immigration status
14.5	1 mark for each benefit of a diverse team, 3 marks available in total. For example, but not limited to: • Higher performance • Greater adaptability • Greater creativity • More perspectives • Broader skills • Stronger community 1 mark for each behaviour of a positive work environment, 2 marks available in total. For example, but not limited to: • People feel they can be themselves at work. • Ideas and respectful challenges are encouraged. • Differences are understood and welcomed. • Communication is collaborative. • Team members support each other through challenging times. • Success is celebrated together.
14.6	(a) 2 (b) 1